

SITONG LI

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May 22, 2026

Dear Prof. Pande, Prof. Schaner, Prof. Troyer-Moore, and the Yale Inclusion Economics Hiring Committee,

I am writing to apply for the Research Associate / Predoctoral Fellow position supporting Yale Inclusion Economics' Kenya-based portfolio of applied development economics research. I am currently a full-time predoctoral research fellow at the Ross School of Business, University of Michigan, where I build and manage large-scale data infrastructure for applied economics research. The opportunity to bring these skills — cleaning and managing complex administrative datasets, conducting rigorous statistical analyses, and supporting the full research production cycle — to YIE's work evaluating digital empowerment interventions for women in East Africa is exactly where I want to direct my career, and I am eager to contribute.

At Michigan Ross, I work full-time as a predoctoral research fellow under faculty at Michigan, Yale, and Barnard. My core work is cleaning and managing large, heterogeneous administrative datasets: I built a scalable entity resolution pipeline integrating LLMs, fuzzy string matching, and word embeddings to link student application records across multiple institutional sources, and designed a computer vision pipeline for structured, large-scale demographic analysis. Working in a full-time, embedded research role — with responsibility for the data infrastructure that faculty depend on to produce results — has sharpened my ability to independently manage ambiguous data problems, maintain rigorous documentation, and deliver reliable outputs under academic timelines. It has also confirmed my commitment to the research path: I am actively preparing for a Ph.D. in economics, and a position supporting cutting-edge development economics research is the strongest foundation I can build toward that goal.

My most relevant methodological experience is from a research assistantship with Prof. Haiwen Zhang at the University of Minnesota on a project analyzing regulatory enforcement by the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. I converted ten years of scanned regulatory correspondence into structured, analysis-ready datasets using OCR and regular expressions, managing over 100,000 documents across 1,000+ regulated entities. I then cleaned and merged those records with EPA administrative enforcement data and conducted probit regression analyses to examine the causal determinants of enforcement actions. This project — converting messy, real-world administrative records into panel data suitable for causal inference, in service of a policy-relevant research question — is closely analogous to the data-intensive survey and monitoring data work described in this position. In a concurrent project with Prof. Zhang, I validated empirical findings through panel regressions and event study models estimated in Stata across 10,000+ corporate filings, and as a research assistant to Prof. William Cassidy at Washington University in St. Louis, I conducted regression analyses linking macroeconomic outcomes to patterns documented in 70 years of congressional testimony. I am proficient in Stata, R, and Python, and am comfortable with the full workflow from raw

data to econometric results.

I am also a strong written communicator. Across my research assistant positions, I have prepared analytical summaries, structured data documentation, and contributed to draft research materials for both academic and practitioner audiences. I am prepared to support literature reviews, background research, grant proposals, project reports, and research protocols of the kind this position requires. I am enthusiastic about the field research dimension of this role as well. I understand the position involves travel to study sites across Kenya and close collaboration with field research teams and implementing partner organizations, and I welcome the opportunity to work in that context. I am committed to the mission of policy-relevant development economics research conducted rigorously in the field, and I am prepared to contribute effectively in the environments that meaningful East Africa field work requires.

YIE's research agenda — evaluating interventions to empower women as digital actors and ensuring digital programs are gender-intentional — sits at the intersection of development economics and public policy where I believe the most important applied work is being done. I would be honored to contribute to it. I look forward to the opportunity to discuss how my background fits the needs of Prof. Pande's team and YIE's Kenya portfolio.

Sincerely,

Sitong Li

Sitong Li

Ann Arbor, MI · 9522014026 · ruc.sitongli@gmail.com

EDUCATION

University of Minnesota, Carlson School of Management

Minneapolis, MN

M.S. in Finance & Business Analytics — GPA: 3.97 / 4.00

Jun 2023 – Aug 2025

- Honors: Carlson Scholar (highest academic award), Merit-Based Scholarship
- GMAT Focus Edition 655 (equivalent to 710 on Classic GMAT)
- Relevant Coursework: Causal Inference, Predictive Analytics, Financial Econometrics, Big Data Analytics

Renmin University of China, School of Business

Beijing, China

B.B.A. in Accounting

Sep 2019 – Jun 2023

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Ross School of Business, University of Michigan

Ann Arbor, MI

Research Analyst

Nov 2025 – Present

- Cleaned and managed large-scale administrative datasets, building a scalable entity resolution pipeline integrating LLMs, FuzzyWuzzy string matching, and word embeddings to link student application records across heterogeneous institutional sources
- Designed a computer vision pipeline to infer demographic attributes from applicant photos, enabling structured, large-scale population analysis in support of cross-institutional equity research
- Prepared analysis-ready datasets and research outputs to support a cross-functional team of faculty at Yale, Barnard, and Michigan, meeting academic production timelines

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Carlson School of Management, University of Minnesota

Research Assistant to Prof. Haiwen (Helen) Zhang (Environmental Policy & Enforcement)

Mar 2025 – Aug 2025

- Cleaned and merged large administrative datasets from EPA enforcement records and regulatory correspondence; ran probit regressions to examine causal determinants of enforcement actions
- Converted 10 years of scanned regulatory emails into structured, analysis-ready text using OCR and regular expressions, managing a corpus of 100,000+ documents across 1,000+ entities
- Applied GPT-4 to extract key policy topics and inquiry points from regulatory correspondence, producing structured outputs for downstream statistical analyses
- Built a GPT-4-powered search bot integrated with the Google Search API to retrieve entity-specific contextual information
- Used generative models to identify whether inquiries targeted public firms and extracted corresponding company names

Carlson School of Management, University of Minnesota

Research Assistant to Prof. Haiwen (Helen) Zhang (Climate Risk Disclosure)

Nov 2023 – Aug 2025

- Validated findings through panel regressions and event study models estimated in Stata across 10,000+ corporate filings
- Built a web crawler to collect and parse 10,000+ full-text 10-K filings from SEC EDGAR for large-scale disclosure analysis
- Segmented filings into structured sections (Item 1A, Item 7, etc.) using regex and HTML parsing for item-level analysis
- Applied BERT and rule-based classifiers to detect and quantify climate risk disclosures across 500,000+ sentences
- Measured textual readability and systemic risk exposure using metrics from Campbell et al. (2014)
- Analyzed fair value disclosures in bank 10-Ks using GPT-4 applied to segmented text chunks

Olin School of Business, Washington University in St. Louis

Research Assistant to Prof. William Cassidy (Empirical Macro-Finance)

Nov 2024 – Nov 2025

- Conducted regression analyses linking macroeconomic outcomes to partisan rhetoric patterns documented in 70 years of fiscal policy hearings
- Scraped and merged member demographics (House/Senate), chamber majority composition, and session metadata into an analysis-ready panel dataset

- Applied GPT-4 to classify topics and extract fiscal policy indicators (fiscal actions, policy styles) from 100,000+ lines of congressional testimony
- Digitized 1950s-era congressional hearing transcripts from scanned PDFs into structured text using the multimodal LLM Donut
- Employed BERT-based entity resolution to link speaker identities to party affiliation and measure partisan sentiment in testimonies
- Built an MNIR-inspired model (Gentzkow, Shapiro & Taddy, *Econometrica*, 2019) using word embeddings to quantify ideological divergence across party lines
- Computed cross-sectional dispersion in sentiment by speaker role and party affiliation across congressional sessions

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

China International Capital Corporation (CICC)

Beijing, China

Equity Strategy Intern

Jun 2023 – Aug 2023

- Led HK-listed stock industry reclassification using an NLP model trained on A-share descriptions, achieving 90% primary and 70% secondary classification accuracy
- Synthesized macroeconomic growth and inflation factors to guide equity investment decisions using hypothesis testing

Harvest Fund Management Co., Ltd.

Beijing, China

Fixed-Income Research Intern

Dec 2022 – May 2023

- Estimated high-frequency duration of 30,000+ fixed-income funds using Ridge, Lasso, and convex optimization
- Built an attention-based pricing model with 80 bps accuracy improvement; implemented Campisi decomposition across 30,000+ holdings

China International Capital Corporation (CICC)

Beijing, China

Quantitative Research Intern

Jul 2022 – Dec 2022

- Applied difference-in-differences to evaluate the effect of employee stock ownership plans on stock prices; designed strategy achieving 2% abnormal return
- Analyzed 3,000+ mutual funds using Sharpe ratio and Fama-French factor models with rolling estimation windows

Harvest Fund Management Co., Ltd.

Beijing, China

Quantitative Research Intern

Jan 2022 – Jul 2022

- Estimated high-frequency positions of 300+ thematic/index funds; identified predictive raw-material price factors via XGBoost
- Designed an EV sector scoring strategy; managed underlying data via SQL-based databases

SKILLS

Programming: Stata, R, Python, SQL, MATLAB, C++, Java, OCaml

Tools & Platforms: Git, L^AT_EX, Unix/Bash, Vim, Databricks, Spark, AWS, SAS, Slurm, HTML

Languages: English (Fluent), Mandarin (Native)

REFERENCES

Francesca Truffa

Assistant Professor Economics
University of Michigan
ftruffa@umich.edu

William M. Cassidy

Assistant Professor of Finance
Washington University in St. Louis
cassidyw@wustl.edu
+1 (225) 368-7616

Haiwen (Helen) Zhang

Professor of Accounting
University of Minnesota
zhan0400@umn.edu
+1 (612) 624-9818

University of Minnesota Unofficial Transcript

Name : Li,Sitong
 Student ID : 5889737
 Birthdate : 1 - 14

Print Date: 09/10/2025

TERM GPA : 4.000 TERM TOTALS : 6.00 6.00 6.00 24.000

MOST RECENT PROGRAMS

Campus : University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Program : Carlson School of Management
 Plan : Business Analytics M S
 Degree Sought : Master of Science
 Advisor : Matson,Evan

 Program : Carlson School of Management
 Plan : Finance M S
 Degree Sought : Master of Science
 Advisor : Lyght,Laura

Fall Semester 2024

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Finance M S

 University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Business Analytics M S

Course	Description	Attempted	Earned	Grade	Points
MSBA 6121	Intro to Stats for Scientists	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6131	Intro to Business Analytics	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6311	Programming for Data Science	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6321	Data Mgmt, DB & Data Warehsing	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6335	Comm for Analytics Profession	0.50	0.50	A	2.000
TERM GPA :	4.000	TERM TOTALS :	12.50	12.50	12.50 50.000

Spring Semester 2025

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Finance M S

 University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Business Analytics M S

Course	Description	Attempted	Earned	Grade	Points
MSBA 6331	Big Data Analytics	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6335	Comm for Analytics Profession	0.50	0.50	A	2.000
MSBA 6411	Exploratory Data Analytics	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6421	Predictive Analytics	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSBA 6441	Inference via Econmtrcs Exprmnt	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
TERM GPA :	4.000	TERM TOTALS :	12.50	12.50	12.50 50.000

Summer Semester 2025

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Finance M S

 University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Business Analytics M S

Course	Description	Attempted	Earned	Grade	Points
MSBA 6341	Responsible AI	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSBA 6345	Agile Project Management	1.00	1.00	A	4.000
MSBA 6431	Times Series Forecasting	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSBA 6494	Directed Research	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSBA 6511	BA Experiential Learning	5.00	5.00	A	20.000
TERM GPA :	4.000	TERM TOTALS :	12.00	12.00	12.00 48.000

Graduate Career Totals

CUM GPA: 3.978 UM TOTALS: 62.00 62.00 62.00 246.666
 UM + TRANSFER TOTALS: 62.00

Spring Semester 2024

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Finance M S

Course	Description	Attempted	Earned	Grade	Points
MSF 6021	Communications for Finance	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6223	Corp & Entrepreneurial Finance	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6621	Finance within Macroeconomy	2.00	2.00	A	8.000

***** End of Transcript *****

- - - - University of Minnesota Degrees and Certificates Awarded - - - -

Degree: Master of Science
 Confer Date: 08/29/2025
 Acad Program: Carlson School of Management
 Plan: Finance M S

Degree: Master of Science
 Confer Date: 08/29/2025
 Acad Program: Carlson School of Management
 Plan: Business Analytics M S

* * * * * Beginning of Graduate Record * * * * *

Summer Semester 2023

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Finance M S

Course	Description	Attempted	Earned	Grade	Points
MSF 6031	Financial Accounting	3.00	3.00	A	12.000
MSF 6221	Finance I: Risk, Return, Value	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6421	Computing for Finance	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
TERM GPA :	4.000	TERM TOTALS :	7.00	7.00	7.00 28.000

Fall Semester 2023

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities
 Carlson School of Management
 Finance M S

Course	Description	Attempted	Earned	Grade	Points
MSF 6121	Fixed Income and Securities	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6222	Finance II: Cash Flow	2.00	2.00	B+	6.666
MSF 6321	Quantitative Port. Analysis	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6322	Corporate Valuation & Modeling	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6422	Financial Econometrics	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
MSF 6522	Derivatives and Risk Managment	2.00	2.00	A	8.000
TERM GPA :	3.889	TERM TOTALS :	12.00	12.00	12.00 46.666



EVALUATION - NOT AN OFFICIAL COPY

Reference Number: 6469005

Date completed: May 1, 2024

U.S. EQUIVALENCY SUMMARY

Bachelor's degree from a regionally accredited institution

CREDENTIAL ANALYSIS

1. Name on Credential:	LI, Sitong
<i>Credential Authentication:</i>	<i>Documents verified by CSSD</i>
Country or Territory:	China
Credential:	Bachelor of Management
Year:	2023
Awarded By:	Renmin University of China
Status:	Accredited Institution
Admission Requirements:	Graduation Certificate (Senior High School)
Length of Program:	Four years
Major:	Accounting
U.S. Equivalency	Bachelor's degree



INSTITUTIONS-DATES-SUBJECTS	Credits	Grades
Renmin University of China		
2019-2020		
(L) Principles of Economics	2.0	A
Physical Education	0.0	B
(L) Ethics and Basic Law Concepts	1.0	A
(L) Seminar for Freshmen	1.0	Pass
(L) Calculus C I	3.0	A
(L) Foreign Language (English) Listening and Speaking	1.0	B
(L) Foreign Language (English) Reading and Writing	1.0	B
(L) Principles of Management	3.0	B
(L) Mental Health 101	1.0	A
(L) Strategic Management	3.0	A
(L) Philosophy of Art	2.0	B
(L) Compendium of Chinese Modern History	1.0	B
(L) Humanities and Writing	1.0	A
(L) Research Methods for Social Sciences	2.0	A
(L) Calculus C II	3.0	C
(L) Academic English Viewing, Listening and Speaking	1.0	A
(L) Organizational Behavior	3.0	A
Career Development Planning	0.0	A
(L) A Survey of Societies and Cultures of Major English-Speaking Countries	2.0	B
(L) The Basics of Information Technology	2.0	A
(L) Reading of Classical Historical Works (General Histories, Dynastic Histories)	1.0	A
(L) Principles of Economics II	2.0	B
2020-2021		
(L) Principles of Marketing Science	3.0	A
(L) Badminton-IFC	1.0	B
(L) Basic Principles of Marxism	1.0	B
(L) Application of Big Data and Internet+	2.0	A
(L) ERP Sand Table Simulation	2.0	A
(L) Introduction to Merchandising and Advertising	2.0	A
(L) Financing of the Start-up Business	2.0	A
(L) Mao Zedong Thought and the Theory of Socialism with Chinese Characteristics	1.0	B
(L) Big Data and Human Resource Analysis	2.0	A
(L) Questionnaire Design and Evaluation	2.0	A
(L) Public Speaking	2.0	B
(L) Ecological Civilization and Sustainable Development	2.0	A
Military Theory	0.0	A
(L) Probability and Statistics C	3.0	C
(L) Mao Zedong Thought and the Theory of Socialism with Chinese Characteristics	1.0	B
(L) A Fine Reading of Renjian Cihua	2.0	A
(L) A Fine Reading on Poems of Dream of the Red Chamber	2.0	A
(L) Financial Management	3.0	B
(L) Statistics (English)	3.0	B
(L) Linear Algebra C	3.0	C
(L) Reading of Classical Historical Works (Specialized Histories)	1.0	A
(L) Oral English Course	1.0	A
2021-2022		
(U) Contemporary World Economy and Politics	2.0	A
(U) Financial Accounting	4.0	C



(L) Introduction to Xi Jinping Thought on Socialism with Chinese Characteristics for a New Era	1.0	A
(U) Cost and Management Accounting	3.0	C
(U) Econometrics (English)	3.0	B
(U) Machine Learning and Computational Intelligence I	3.0	C
(U) Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning	2.0	A
(U) Robotic Process Automation	2.0	A
(U) Big Data in Auditing	3.0	B
(U) Big Data Technology	3.0	A
(U) Machine Learning and Natural Language Processing	3.0	A
(U) Basics of Python Programming	2.0	A
(U) Data Mining	2.0	B
(U) Liberal Arts Writing	2.0	A
(U) Advanced Accounting	3.0	A
Thesis Writing	1.0	B
(U) Database Theory and Application	2.0	B
(U) Business Data Analysis	2.0	A
(U) Business Intelligence and Visualization	2.0	A
(U) Introduction to Artificial Intelligence	2.0	A
(U) Intelligent Accounting	3.0	A
(U) Quantamental Investing	2.0	A
2022-2023		
(U) Accounting	3.0	B
Military Training	0.0	A
(U) Accounting Information System	2.0	B
Graduation Thesis	4.0	C
Physical Education	0.0	C
Physical Education	0.0	B
Professional Practice	1.0	A
(U) Social Research and Innovation Practice	2.0	A
(U) Aesthetic Principle	2.0	A
Social Practice and Voluntary Service	0.0	Pass
(U) National Conditions and Current Policies	2.0	Pass
(U) Data Science	3.0	A
(U) The History and Culture of Mongolian and Tibetan	2.0	A

SUMMARY

Total Undergraduate Semester Credits:

150.0 GPA: 3.41



WES EVALUATION TERMS

Evaluation Scope: World Education Services (WES) evaluates only formal educational credentials. WES does not evaluate professional experience. WES evaluations are based upon the best information and resources available to professional evaluators. WES evaluations are offered as non-binding advisory opinions.

Accredited Institution: The status of a nationally recognized institution in another country is comparable to that of a regionally accredited institution in the United States.

Credential Authentication: Evaluations prepared by WES specify the manner in which each document was authenticated. The method used depends on what is appropriate for the specific country and level of education. WES authenticates academic records by one of the following methods.

- by requiring that official transcripts be sent to WES directly by the institutions or examination bodies that issued them;
OR
- by requiring that official transcripts be authenticated by the relevant government authority (e.g. Ministry of Education) before being sent directly to WES;
OR
- by verifying documents submitted by individuals by sending them back to the institutions/examination bodies that issued them and obtaining a written confirmation of their authenticity.

Detailed country-by-country document requirements can be viewed at www.wes.org/required/index.asp

Grades/ Quality Points: WES uses an alphabetic system to identify grades. The standard WES conversion of letter grades into a numerical scale/quality points is as follows: A = 4.00; A- = 3.67; B+ = 3.33; B = 3.00; B- = 2.67; C+ = 2.33; C = 2.00; C- = 1.67; D+ = 1.33; D = 1.00; F = 0; F* = (see below); R* = (see below)

- “F*” indicates a course that was failed initially, but passed on a subsequent attempt. It is not included in the GPA calculation.
- “R*” indicates a course that was passed initially, but was retaken for grade improvement. It is not included in the GPA calculation.
- “Pass” is not included in the Cumulative Grade Point Average. For study completed at the undergraduate level, it corresponds to at least a “C” in the United States. For graduate and professional study, “Pass” corresponds to at least a “B”.

Grade Point Average (GPA) is calculated by multiplying the credits per course by the quality points for the grade for that course, repeating this procedure for each course, totaling the credit hour quality points thus obtained, and dividing by the total number of credits.

Course Level Designation: The designation “U” (upper) or “L” (lower) for a course at the undergraduate level is an indication of its level.

Credit Recognition and Transfer: The course-by-course analysis represents a breakdown of post-secondary study in terms of U.S. semester credits and grade equivalents. The number of credits accepted for transfer to a degree program or towards a professional license in the United States may vary from those listed in this report in accordance with the policies of the receiving educational institution or professional agency.

Evaluations for Professional Licensing/Certification: WES does not assess professional aptitude or experience. Only authorities qualified in the profession can determine whether an individual meets requirements for licensing or to practice the profession in the United States.